India & Sudan: Building Bridges, Expanding Opportunities, Shaping a Shared Future

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FOREWORD

Sudan occupies a distinctive and, in many respects, underexplored position within Africa's economic landscape. Endowed with vast arable land, significant mineral and livestock resources, and a strategic location linking the Red Sea, the Sahel and the wider East African region, the country holds long-term potential across agriculture, mining, energy and trade-linked infrastructure. At the same time, prolonged conflict, institutional disruption and infrastructure gaps have constrained the pace and predictability of economic activity, shaping a landscape where opportunity and risk sit closely together, and where rebuilding and diversification will define the years ahead.

India and Sudan share a longstanding relationship rooted in historical ties, developmental cooperation and an expanding agenda of engagement across agriculture, mining, healthcare, education and skills, infrastructure, and trade. Trade has historically spanned pharmaceuticals, agricultural inputs, machinery, textiles and consumer goods moving from India, against Sudanese exports of oilseeds, gum Arabic, livestock products and select minerals. While the ongoing conflict has disrupted trade volumes, logistics and normal business operations, the underlying complementarities between the two economies remain intact India's manufacturing and pharmaceutical strength alongside Sudan's agricultural and resource base continue to offer a durable basis for engagement once conditions permit fuller-scale activity. This paper takes care to present these linkages as they stand today, distinguishing established patterns from areas of future potential.

Looking ahead, the paper outlines a practical set of initiatives through which CCI India can support Indian businesses in staying engaged with Sudan in a manner appropriate to current conditions whether through knowledge sharing, institutional dialogue with the Embassy of Sudan in India, or early-stage relationship building with Sudanese counterparts that can be scaled as stability improves. This Knowledge Paper examines, in a structured and evidence-based manner, the current state of Sudan's economy, its major sectors, and the opportunities and constraints shaping India-Sudan economic engagement, serving as a reference for CCI India's engagement with the Embassy, Sudanese stakeholders, and Indian companies assessing the market.



Munindra Kumar
Director General
CCI India

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SUDAN

> Explore ancient pyramids and cultural depth along the Nile.



Introduction

Sudan is a large North-African country with strategic position and abundant resources (gold 70% of exports), but the April 2023 civil conflict has severely disrupted economic activity, government finances, and bilateral trade with India. Political stabilization could enable cooperation in mining, agri-processing, and renewable energy.

India and Sudan maintain an established diplomatic relationship, with Sudan operating a resident embassy in New Delhi. This mission serves as the primary channel for political dialogue, trade facilitation, and consular services between the two nations.

Basic Facts & Demographics

Sudan is a republic with its capital at Khartoum. Current demographic estimates place the population at approximately 51.7 million, making it one of Africa's most populous countries, though figures remain contested due to the ongoing civil conflict that began in 2023. The national currency is the Sudanese Pound (SDG).
Sudan's substantial young population and arable land reserves have historically shaped domestic-market potential and labor availability, although persistent instability currently constrains economic growth and reliable demographic census data.

Embassy Of Sudan In India — Role & Functions

The Embassy of the Republic of Sudan in New Delhi executes core diplomatic functions: it advances bilateral political dialogue, facilitates trade and investment flows, organizes business delegations, supports cultural and academic exchanges, and delivers consular services to Sudanese citizens and Indian visa applicants. The mission serves as a practical contact point for Indian firms exploring procurement, supply contracts, or project opportunities in Sudan—including energy, agricultural inputs, and mineral sectors—and for Sudanese students, investors, and travelers engaging with India.

Culture and Heritage

Sudan's culture reflects a blend of Arab and African influences, shaped by its long history along the Nile. Diverse ethnic groups maintain distinct traditions, languages, and customs. Music, dance, and oral traditions play a key role in cultural expression, while crafts such as pottery, textiles, and leatherwork are widely practiced. Islam is the dominant religion and strongly influences daily life and cultural practices.

Economy — GDP, Structure & Recent Performance

Sudan's economy is natural-resource-intensive, historically dominated by oil (pre-2011), gold mining, and agriculture, with pre-conflict nominal GDP estimates ranging $30–50 billion. However, the economy has contracted dramatically since the April 2023 civil conflict, with the World Bank documenting severe GDP declines, government finance disruptions, currency devaluation, and infrastructure damage that weakens agricultural production and mineral extraction. These conditions materially constrain Sudan's import capacity, reduce government contracting, elevate investor risk significantly, and disrupt bilateral trade flows with India, while recovery timelines remain uncertain pending political stabilization



Economic & Strategic Areas Of Cooperation

Historically, Practical Cooperation Areas Between India And Sudan Have Included Agricultural Commodities (Sesame, Groundnuts), Pharmaceuticals, Petroleum & Petroleum Products, Engineering Goods, And Technical Cooperation/Itec Programmes. India Has Been A Supplier Of Affordable Medicines, Machinery And Foodstuffs, While Sudan Has Supplied Oil, Minerals And Agricultural Raw Materials.
Potential Future Cooperation (Contingent On Stability) Could Expand Into Mining/ Gold Value-Chains, Agri-Processing, Renewable Energy And Selective Infrastructure Projects — Areas Where Indian Firms Have Competitive Experience.

Conclusion & Recommendations

Sudan is a resource-rich partner for India with historical commercial ties and a resident embassy in New Delhi facilitating bilateral contacts. However, the ongoing conflict since 2023 has produced severe humanitarian and macroeconomic shocks, interrupted trade channels, and sharply increased commercial and political risk.

For policy-grade reporting, cite up-to-date multilateral data (UN/World Bank), official embassy briefs, and ComTrade/Trading Economics for trade figures. Recommended short-term actions for stakeholders: prioritize trade in low-touch goods (pharma, packaged food, engineering spares); avoid large green-field investments until stability returns; and use embassies and trade promotion bodies for real-time intelligence and payment guarantees.

1. Country Profile

A business oriented profile of the Republic of Sudan for Indian industry, investors and institutional stakeholders. Sudan is Africa's third largest country by land area and occupies a strategically important position linking Sub Saharan Africa, North Africa, the Nile Basin and the Red Sea/Middle East corridor. The country has been in a state of civil conflict since April 2023, and the snapshot below distinguishes long standing structural facts (geography, resources) from economic indicators that have shifted materially because of the conflict.

For Indian industry, Sudan represents a market with significant underlying economic potential despite the severe constraints created by the ongoing conflict. Its large agricultural base, natural resources, Red Sea access and position within regional trade routes provide a foundation for longer term commercial engagement. At the same time, businesses must distinguish between opportunities that can be pursued under current conditions and those that are more appropriately considered as part of Sudan's medium to long term recovery and reconstruction.

Table: Sudan Country Snapshot

Parameter	Detail
Official Name	Republic of the Sudan
Capital	Khartoum (de jure); Port Sudan has functioned as the interim seat of government and diplomatic activity since 2023 due to the conflict)
Population	48.1 million (2023, World Bank/UN base estimate); subsequent estimates for 2025 range c. 50–52 million depending on methodology and displacement adjustments figures are unusually volatile due to conflict driven displacement and should be treated as indicative.
Area	1,886,068 sq. km 3rd largest country in Africa
Currency	Sudanese Pound (SDG)
Official Languages	Arabic and English
Political Structure	Transitional governance under military led authorities amid ongoing conflict between the Sudanese Armed Forces (SAF) and the Rapid Support Forces (RSF); a Transitional Prime Minister (Kamil El Tayeb Idris, as of late 2025) heads a transitional civilian administration aligned with the SAF led authorities
Administrative Divisions	18 states (wilayat)

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Parameter	Detail
Major Cities	Khartoum, Omdurman, Khartoum North (Bahri), Port Sudan, Kassala, El Obeid, Nyala, Wad Madani, Atbara
Geographic Location	North East Africa; bordered by Egypt, Libya, Chad, Central African Republic, South Sudan, Ethiopia and Eritrea, with a Red Sea coastline
Major Port	Port Sudan Sudan's principal seaport on the Red Sea and its main gateway for external trade
Key Land Borders	Egypt (north), Libya (north west), Chad (west), Central African Republic (south west), South Sudan (south), Ethiopia (south east), Eritrea (east)
Natural Resources	Gold and other minerals, petroleum, arable land, livestock, gum Arabic, fisheries, forestry resources
Trade/Regional Groupings	African Union (AU), African Continental Free Trade Area (AFTRA signed), Common Market for Eastern and Southern Africa (COMESA), Arab League, World Trade Organization (WTO)

1.1 Geography

Sudan sits at the crossroads of Sub Saharan Africa, North Africa and the Arabian Peninsula, with direct access to the Red Sea one of the world's busiest maritime trade corridors linking the Indian Ocean to the Mediterranean via the Suez Canal. This geography gives Sudan a structural relevance for India that goes beyond bilateral trade volumes: Port Sudan sits on the same Red Sea shipping lane used by a substantial share of India's trade with Europe and the Mediterranean.

The country's major geographic regions include the Nile Valley (the historic agricultural spine of the country, fed by the Blue Nile and White Nile which converge at Khartoum), the semi-arid central plains (including the Gezira Scheme, one of the largest irrigated agricultural schemes in the world), the western regions of Darfur and Kordofan (predominantly pastoral and rain fed agricultural, and the epicentre of the current conflict), and the eastern coastal belt along the Red Sea anchored by Port Sudan and Kassala.

For regional connectivity, Sudan borders seven countries and is geographically positioned to serve as a potential logistics and trade corridor between the Red Sea and landlocked or Nile Basin neighbours, including South Sudan, Chad, Central African Republic and Ethiopia a role that is presently constrained by conflict but remains structurally significant for long term planning.

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Sudan's location also provides access to important regional markets through the Red Sea and its connections with the wider Horn of Africa and Middle East. Port Sudan serves as the country's principal maritime gateway and plays a critical role in the movement of imports, exports and humanitarian supplies. Its proximity to the Arabian Peninsula and established maritime routes creates potential for Sudan to function as a commercial link between African markets and Asian trading partners, including India. As regional trade networks expand, improvements in port infrastructure, road connectivity, customs systems and logistics services could further strengthen Sudan's role as a regional trade and transit hub.

1.2 Demographics

Population: approximately 48.1 million as of the 2023 baseline (World Bank); the conflict has since driven large scale internal and cross border displacement, making precise current population distribution difficult to establish with confidence.

Displacement: Sudan is currently the site of the world's largest internal displacement crisis, with over 10 million people displaced within the country and across borders into Chad, Egypt, South Sudan and other neighbouring states since April 2023, according to humanitarian trackers and UN agencies.

Urbanisation and youth population: Sudan has historically had a young, growing population with a large working age cohort; pre conflict labour force estimates stood at approximately 12.06 million.

Employment structure: agriculture has traditionally absorbed the largest share of the workforce (historical estimates put this as high as 80% in 1998), with industry and services accounting for smaller shares; unemployment was estimated at 25% in 2020 and is understood to have risen sharply amid the conflict driven collapse of formal economic activity, though robust recent labour force surveys are not available.

Sudan’s demographic structure has important implications for its economic recovery. The country has a large young population, creating substantial long term potential for workforce development, entrepreneurship and consumer market growth. However, conflict related displacement, disruption of education and employment, and reduced access to basic services have weakened human capital development. Supporting skills development, vocational education, entrepreneurship and private sector employment will therefore be important for converting Sudan’s demographic potential into productive economic capacity.

The concentration of livelihoods in agriculture also makes rural economic recovery particularly important. Restoring agricultural production, strengthening food processing and value chains, and improving access to finance, inputs, technology and markets could support both employment and food security. At the same time, rebuilding urban economic activity will require the revival of small and medium enterprises, trade, logistics and essential services.

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